



say he is. At least in the Olympic final. In his semifinal heat, he was beaten to the finish by Jamaica's Oblique Seville — adding more drama to the event.

It's unlikely this was exactly what he had planned, but Lyles, who's part of a *Netflix* series *Sprint* — which he hopes will do for track and field what

Drive to Survive did for Formula 1 — is not particularly averse to drama. He's not short on hyperbole and self-promotion either. At a press conference before the Games, Lyles declared himself the fastest man alive. "It's me. It's always going to be me."

For all his bluster, the fact is that until he came to Paris, the 27-year-old didn't have the hardware to back it up. He only had a bronze in the 200m at Tokyo. He might have won three gold medals — 100m, 200m, and 4x100m — at the World Championships last year, but he wasn't the fastest this year. That title still belonged to Kishane Thompson.

A surprise loss to Jamaica's Seville in the semifinals, combined with being slower than Thompson, set the stage not for a crowning victory but for a very public comeuppance.

All his talk of being a star and revolutionising the sport had to start with a gold on the biggest stage, and even that didn't seem like a guarantee. Having talked the talk, it was time for him to walk the walk — or at least sprint the sprint. To Lyles' credit, he didn't betray any nerves as he took his place in the lineup in lane seven, just to the right of Seville.

The man who had said he had the 'mindset of a god' now just mouthed the words 'thank you god'. To his right, Seville made finger guns and

Photo finish: Lyles (centre) with silver medallist Kishane Thompson and bronze medallist Fred Kerly. *AFP*

mock-fired down the track.

By this point, the drama was at a fever pitch. The crowd, which had been buzzing, anxious, and making Mexican waves all evening, became deathly quiet as the runners took their stances. There's really nothing like an Olympic sprint final — the looming, intimidating knowledge that it's over almost as soon as it starts, with people working four years for a run of under 10 seconds.

As the race progressed, the stadium commentators squealed with excitement. The stadium itself was lit by tens of thousands of flashes as the finalists raced to the finish line.

Lyles, dead last at first, pulled himself into contention before stretching his torso ahead right at the finish line (**left; lane 7**). For a few more seconds, everyone looked on in disbelief at the giant screen, which showed a column of photo finishes before declaring Lyles the winner.

He ran all the way around the ground, then onto the grass. It was more a release of emotion than a lap of honour. The stadium celebrated with him as he asserted his right to take centre stage.



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